

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN HAITI

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Haiti is a mountainous Caribbean nation on the island of Hispaniola, the poorest in the entire western hemisphere, whose defining environmental question is the near-total stripping of its steep hillsides of their trees and then of their soil — driven by the charcoal and fuelwood on which most families depend to cook, and the deadly cascade of erosion, flood, and landslide that has followed. This guide is honest from the outset about a crucial point of justice: the charcoal that drives the deforestation is not greed but survival, the fuel of families with no affordable alternative, so the answer can never be to punish the poor with bans, but to offer alternatives, livelihoods, and community-led restoration. And it must be honest that the state has largely collapsed and much of the territory lies under armed-group control, so this work must run very largely from outside and through the community — the vast diaspora, the international partners, and the local efforts that carry on even amid the crisis — always protecting anyone inside. There is no landmark community victory to point to. But the tools that remain are real.

In a collapsed state, the tools that remain are external, communal, and protective, and they are real. The **remaining forest** — the national parks and the last forested slopes — can be defended through their protected-area designations and the international conservation partners who work them. Where a formal project threatens — a donor-financed development that displaces farmers, a mine, a dam — the **environmental assessment and, above all, the lender's and donor's safeguards and accountability mechanisms** are a real, reachable lever, as displaced Haitian communities have shown by bringing such claims. The **vast Haitian diaspora and the international partners** carry documentation, funding, and advocacy from safety. **Community stewardship** protects what remains where it is safe, and **rigorous documentation**, gathered only where safe, grounds it all. But these tools have grave limits, and this guide states them plainly. The deforestation is all but complete, and the poverty driving the charcoal economy is profound — so the answer is never bans on the poor, but alternatives and livelihoods, and the deeper environmental work of Haiti is the community's own reforestation and restoration, a matter of life and death in every storm, not a discrete project to be stopped. The state has collapsed, much of the territory lies under armed-group control, and the disasters are recurrent and climate-amplified. So the work must run from outside and through the community, only where it is safe, avoiding the armed-group areas, and protecting anyone inside absolutely. And there is no landmark victory to point to. So the honest prize is the remaining forest defended, a harmful donor-financed project held to account, and the community's restoration supported with alternatives — resting on the efforts that continue even now, not a single triumphant stop. Above all, protect the people, and never punish the poor.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

You cannot rely on a collapsed state, and you must never punish the poor whose charcoal is survival. What can be done is to defend what remains and hold formal harms to account, from outside and through the community: protect the last forests through their designations and the international conservation partners, hold any donor-financed project to its lender's safeguards and accountability mechanisms, work through the diaspora and international partners, and support the community's own restoration with alternatives — all only where it is safe, and protecting everyone.

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Haiti is among the hardest settings in this guide, and honesty about that is the first discipline. The defining harm is not a discrete project but a near-complete, poverty-driven deforestation, so much of the work is the community's own life-saving restoration, not a fight to be won. The state has collapsed, much of the territory is dangerous, and the charcoal that drives the loss is survival, not greed. So the realistic aim is the remaining forest defended, a formal harmful project held to account through the international channels, and the community's restoration supported with alternatives — pursued from outside, only where safe, and never by punishing the poor.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

Who Actually Decides

With the state collapsed, power on the ground is contested and much of it held by armed groups. The decisions a careful effort can reach are largely external and communal: the **international conservation partners** who work the remaining forests, the **lenders and donors** who finance formal projects and answer to their own safeguards, the **diaspora and international organisations**, and the **community and its local stewardship** where it is safe. Avoid the armed-group areas, and map who can genuinely be reached in safety before spending a week on it.

How a Project Moves — and Where You Jump In

A diffuse harm — the charcoal frontier, the erosion — is met not by stopping a project but by the community's restoration and by defending what forest remains. A formal project — a donor-financed development, a mine, a dam — advances through the state's remnants and its financiers, and there the entry point is the environmental assessment and, above all, the lender's or donor's safeguards and accountability mechanisms, which displaced communities can invoke. Enter through the designations, the safeguards, and the international partners, and only where it is safe.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Follow the finance: which lender or donor backs a formal project, and what safeguards and accountability mechanisms it carries. Follow the forest: which national parks and remaining slopes are protected, and who works them. Follow the charcoal: what drives the frontier, and what alternatives could relieve it. The leverage lies in the protected-area designations, the lender's safeguards, and the international partners.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

Domestic oversight has largely collapsed. The watchers a community can engage are external and communal: the international conservation partners and the protected-area frameworks, the lenders' and donors' safeguard and accountability mechanisms, the diaspora and international organisations, and the community's own stewardship. These are the channels a careful, safe case engages.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

No Haitian effort easily reverses the deforestation, and honesty requires saying so — it is all but complete, driven by survival, in a collapsed state. What the remaining tools can deliver is defence and accountability: the last forests protected through their designations and partners, a donor-financed project held to its safeguards, the community's restoration supported. The single most decisive move is **working through the international conservation partners and the lenders' safeguards**, because in a collapsed state these

external, reachable levers respond to documented harm, and because they can act without endangering anyone inside. The protected-area designations are the durable defence; the lender's safeguards the sharpest handle on a formal project; the restoration the community's own life-saving work. And nothing here is worth a life, or the punishment of the poor.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Ask five questions. **What is the harm?** — a formal project displacing people, a threat to the remaining forest, or the diffuse deforestation itself. **Is it a formal project?** — with a lender or donor whose safeguards apply. **What protects the place?** — a protected-area designation, an international conservation partner. **Which channel is safe?** — the diaspora, the international partners, the community, kept clear of the armed groups. **How is everyone kept safe, and the poor not punished?** — the overriding questions. Pick the harm where an external, safe lever — a designation, a safeguard, a partner — can be reached.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Build the case in layers, safely. **Layer one: the harm** — a formal project's displacement or footprint, or the threat to the remaining forest, documented where it is safe and by satellite where it is not. **Layer two: the protection or safeguard** — the protected-area designation, the lender's or donor's safeguards and accountability mechanisms, the standards the harm breaches. **Layer three: the channel and the safety** — which international partner, safeguard mechanism, or conservation body to reach, and the absolute discipline of avoiding the armed-group areas, protecting everyone, and never targeting the poor. A case built on the designations and the lenders' safeguards, gathered safely, is one the external partners can act on.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Gather the **harm record**: a formal project's displacement and footprint, or the deforestation, documented safely and by satellite. Gather the **protection record**: the protected-area designations, the lenders' and donors' safeguards and accountability mechanisms. Gather the **partner record**: the international conservation partners, the diaspora and international organisations. Gather the **alternatives record**: the charcoal alternatives and livelihoods that relieve the frontier without punishing the poor. Gather the **safety discipline**: confirm the work avoids the armed-group areas, protects everyone, and never targets the poor.

STEP 3: BUILDING THE COMMUNITY, DIASPORA & INTERNATIONAL COALITION

The coalition here is communal, external, and protective. Build it from the **local community and its stewardship**, where it is safe; the **vast Haitian diaspora**, who carry documentation, funding, and advocacy from safety; the **international conservation partners** who defend the remaining forest; and the **lenders', donors', and international organisations'** safeguard and accountability channels. Frame the effort around community restoration and the saving of lives, offering livelihood, not blame; avoid the armed-group areas; protect everyone; and never turn the effort against the poor whose charcoal is survival.

STEP 4: FOREST PROTECTION, SAFEGUARDS & THE DIASPORA — DEFENDING WHAT REMAINS

Set expectations honestly: the levers are external, communal, and partial, in a collapsed state, so the prize is defence, accountability, and support, not a stop.

The Protection of the Remaining Forest

The **remaining forest** — the national parks and the last forested slopes — can be defended through their **protected-area designations and the international conservation partners** who work them. Document a threat to what remains and raise it with the partners and frameworks that guard it — the durable defence of Haiti's last forest.

The Lenders' and Donors' Safeguards

Where a formal project threatens — a donor-financed development, a mine, a dam — the **environmental assessment and the lender's or donor's safeguards and accountability mechanisms** are the sharpest handle, as displaced Haitian communities have shown by bringing such claims. Invoke the safeguards and the accountability mechanisms the financiers must honour.

The Diaspora and the Restoration

The **vast diaspora and the international partners** carry the case from safety, and the **community's own restoration**, supported with alternatives, is the deeper, life-saving work. Pursued together — the forest protection, the safeguards, and the diaspora and restoration — these levers defend what remains and hold formal harms to account, while protecting everyone and never punishing the poor.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Tailor the case to each audience. **For the international conservation partners:** here is a threat to Haiti's last forest, and the designation that protects it. **For the lender or donor:** here is a project that displaces people against your safeguards. **For the accountability mechanism:** here is the documented claim of the affected community. **For the diaspora and international organisations:** here is the case to carry and fund from safety. **For the restoration:** here are the alternatives that relieve the charcoal frontier without punishing the poor. **The golden rule:** work through the external and communal channels, avoid the armed-group areas, protect everyone, and never blame or punish the poor whose charcoal is survival.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media matters, carried largely from outside. Frame the story around **the last forests and the lives at stake:** Haiti's remaining forest and the disasters the deforestation magnifies, and the alternatives and restoration that can help — never as blame on the poor. Carry it through the diaspora networks, the international conservation and development outlets, and the safe community channels. A few cautions govern everything: never expose anyone inside or in an armed-group area; frame it around restoration and lives, not blame; protect everyone; and let the satellite evidence, the designations, and the safeguards carry the weight.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Keep every message external where needed, communal, protective, and just toward the poor.

8A — To an international conservation partner: document the threat to a remaining forest and invoke its protected-area designation.

8B — To a lender or donor: set out a project's displacement or harm against the institution's safeguards.

8C — To a safeguard accountability mechanism: present the affected community's documented claim.

8D — To the diaspora: share the case and ask for documentation, funding, and advocacy from safety.

8E — To an international organisation: describe the harm and request engagement.

8F — On the alternatives: set out the charcoal alternatives and livelihoods that relieve the frontier without bans.

8G — To the community (where safe): set out the restoration and the alternatives, and organise safely.

8H — To the international public: summarise the last forests and the lives at stake, and ask for support — without exposing anyone or blaming the poor.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

The first 48 hours: for a formal project, identify the lender or donor and its safeguards; for the forest, pull the satellite imagery and the designation; write the one-page case. **The fastest-moving levers:** the lenders' safeguards, the protected-area partners, and the diaspora. **Emergency action:** if a donor-financed project is displacing people, reach the lender's accountability mechanism first; if a remaining forest is threatened, reach the conservation partners. Throughout, avoid the armed-group areas, expose no one, and never punish the poor.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

The field here is not merely tilted but collapsed and dangerous: no functioning state, much territory under armed groups, and a harm driven by survival poverty. Recognise it plainly and adjust the aim — not a stop, but the remaining forest defended, a formal harm held to account, and the restoration supported. Lean on the external levers the collapse cannot reach: the protected-area partners, the lenders' safeguards, the diaspora, the international organisations. And accept the honest limits — the deforestation is all but complete, the poverty profound — while still defending what remains and supporting the community's own restoration, and protecting, above all, the people.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO BENEFITS

In a collapsed state, the dangers are the armed groups who hold the land and any who profit from a harmful project while the poor are displaced or blamed. Respond only through the **external and communal channels:** the lenders' safeguards and accountability mechanisms, the international conservation partners, the diaspora, the documented record. Never through anything touching the armed groups. **On safety and protection:** this governs everything. Haiti is in profound crisis, its state collapsed and much of its territory under armed-group control. Work through the community, diaspora, and international channels, only where it is safe; never expose or endanger anyone; avoid the armed-group areas entirely; frame the work as community restoration and the saving of lives, offering livelihood not blame; and never punish the poor. Protection is the governing rule.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE: RUNNING ALL FIVE STEPS TOGETHER

The steps run in parallel, external and communal and only where safe. The documented harm feeds the forest protection, the safeguard claim, and the diaspora advocacy at once; the community, diaspora, and international partners organise alongside; the media carries the last-forests-and-lives frame throughout; the restoration and alternatives run beneath it all. A rough timeline: **weeks one to four**, document the harm and identify the designation, safeguard, or partner; **months two to six**, press the forest protection, the lenders' safeguards, and the diaspora and international partners; **beyond**, sustain the defence and support the community's restoration. The core discipline: external and communal, safe, and never against the poor.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Haiti is among the hardest and most collapsed grounds in this guide, and this guide does not pretend otherwise. It does not claim the deforestation can be reversed, or that a functioning state exists, or that the poor can be blamed for a charcoal economy that is survival, not greed — none of that is true, and much of the territory is dangerous. What it claims is narrower and real: that the remaining forest can be defended through its protected-area designations and the international conservation partners; that a formal, donor-financed project that displaces people can be held to its lender's safeguards and accountability mechanisms, as Haitian communities have shown; that the vast diaspora and the international partners carry the case from safety; and that the community's own restoration, supported with alternatives rather than bans, is the deeper, life-saving work. The levers are external, communal, and partial, and the prize is the last forest defended, a formal harm held to account, and the restoration supported — not a single triumphant stop. For a mountainous, deforested, crisis-stricken nation, that external, communal, protective work — only where safe, and never punishing the poor — is not a lesser ambition. It is the only responsible and effective one.